1.1 War in the Middle States

Have you ever been surprised when a team that seems to have no chance at all actually wins the big game? The Continental Army was that kind of team.

MAIN IDEA Despite its disadvantages, the Continental Army managed to win important battles early on in the American Revolution.

CREATING AN ARMY

In 1775, Great Britain had one of the most powerful armies in the world. Its soldiers were well-trained, experienced professionals, and about 42,000 of them came to fight in the colonies. Great Britain was prepared to meet the troops' needs for arms and other supplies. As you have read, the British also hired Hessian soldiers to join them in the colonies—about 30,000 men. These **mercenaries**, or soldiers who are paid to fight for a country other than their own, further swelled the number of British forces.

On September 9, 1776, the Continental Congress voted to rename the colonies the "United States of America," but the new nation did not have a strong central government. Congress did not have the power to provide funding for arms, other supplies, or soldiers' pay.

This situation didn't change until the next year, when the Continental Congress drafted and adopted the **Articles of Confederation** in 1777. Under the Articles of Confederation, the 13 states mostly governed themselves as small **republics**. A republic is a form of government in which the people elect representatives to speak for them and enact laws based on the people's needs. James Madison helped organize the state government of Virginia. The Articles granted Congress the authority to call on states to help fund the war.

Compared with the British Army, the young Continental Army was ill prepared and disorganized. The Patriots had other problems as well. George Washington faced a huge challenge in turning a collection of local militias into a disciplined, united fighting force. He also had trouble recruiting more troops. Few eligible men had formal military training, and many were unwilling to leave their farms or jobs. Also, not everyone was eager for independence. Families and communities found themselves split between Loyalists and Patriots.

Both free and enslaved African Americans were in a unique situation when it came to deciding where their loyalties lay. The British promised freedom to many enslaved people if they promised to fight on the British side. Other African Americans, both free and unfree, were motivated to try to secure freedom for all and served in the war with the Patriots.

In 1776, only around 20,000 men had joined the Continental Army, but despite this and its numerous other problems, the Continental Army did have some advantages over the British. Most importantly, its soldiers were fighting a **defensive war**, or a war to protect one's own land, on familiar ground, while the British Army was far from home. And Americans were fighting for their homes and way of life.

EARLY VICTORIES AND DEFEATS

Even though the Revolution started in New England, it quickly spread to the Middle States of New York, New Jersey, Pennsylvania, and Delaware. In July 1776, British troops landed on New York's Staten Island and pushed American troops back to Manhattan Island and then New Jersey. The Continental Army soon had to escape across the Delaware River into Pennsylvania.

But the Continental Army had a change of luck by the end of the year. When they crossed the icy Delaware River on Christmas Day, Washington and his troops surprised and defeated the Hessian defenders in Trenton, New Jersey. The Hessian commander had received orders to build defenses

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Each December, the Old Barracks Museum in Trenton, New Jersey, hosts a reenactment of the battle that showed the determination of American troops as they marched in blinding snow. The leaflet shown here provides an account of the battle—which lasted only 35 minutes—and the American victory. It took the news 11 days to reach Salem, Massachusetts, and appear in print on January 6.

around Trenton, but he had ignored them. On the night before the battle, he got a message informing him that the Continental Army was on its way. He ignored this as well, and the result was a major defeat for the British. After this American victory, called the **Battle of Trenton**, British general **William Howe** withdrew most of his army back to New York. In the words of one British officer, the Americans had "become a formidable [fearsome] enemy." This victory resulted in a wave of support and enthusiasm for the American cause, which encouraged recruitment—and greater victories.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What advantages and disadvantages did the Continental Army have at the start of the American Revolution?
2. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** How do you think questions over national identity might have affected military recruitment? Explain why.
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** How did the Articles of Confederation impact the American Revolution?

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